

Terraform Drift is the most
asked Terraform question in
Devops interviews

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Here's how to answer it
correctly →

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What is Terraform drift?

It's when someone manually modifies infrastructure that Terraform is already managing.

Your Terraform state says one thing, but the actual infrastructure is different.

Example of Drift

- Your Terraform creates an EC2 instance with type `t2.micro`.
- Someone goes to AWS console and manually changes it to `t2.large`
- That's drift.

Terraform thinks it's `t2.micro` but AWS shows `t2.large`.

When you run `terraform apply`, Terraform will change it back to `t2.micro`.

Important to Understand

If someone manually creates a new resource that's not in your Terraform code, that's NOT drift.

Terraform only cares about resources it's managing.

It ignores everything else.

Why Does Drift Happen?

- Someone makes manual changes in the cloud console to Terraform-managed resources
- Another automation tool modifies the same infrastructure
- Emergency fixes applied directly without updating Terraform code

How Do You Detect It?

→ Run `terraform plan`

It shows the differences between your code and actual state

→ Run `terraform refresh`

Updates state file with current reality

Set up drift detection in CI/CD
Catch it automatically

How Do You Prevent It?

- ✓ Use proper IAM policies so only Terraform can modify infrastructure
- ✓ Enable state locking to prevent concurrent changes
- ✓ Make it a rule: if Terraform manages it, nobody touches it manually

✓ Best Answer in an Interview

"Drift happens when someone manually modifies infrastructure that Terraform is managing.

I prevent it by enforcing strict access controls, using remote state locking, and running drift detection in CI/CD.

If drift occurs, terraform apply will revert the manual changes back to what's defined in code."

That's It

Simple, accurate, and shows you actually understand how Terraform works.

Save this for your next interview.

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